

Via Nova SPRING NEWSLETTER

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Dear Friends and Family,

My fall newsletter was quite long and detailed, written with the hope of giving you a fuller picture of what Via is, why I chose this year of formation, and what life in the program had looked like up to that point. This time, as the year is coming to a close, I would like to use this newsletter as an opportunity to reflect on how each aspect of Via—intellectual, professional, spiritual, and communal—has been formative for myself, the other Fellows, and even the wider community.

STUDY

The intellectual formation I received in Via this year was not just about acquiring knowledge; it was about awakening wonder, cultivating wisdom, and seeking truth. We weren't simply studying



seminar with John at the women's house ("St. Julien's")

ideas; we were entering into a centuries-old conversation about what it means to live well, to be human, and to seek the good.

Reading Plato's *Republic* invited us to consider justice, not just as a societal principle, but as a condition of the soul. In this work, the character Socrates leads the dialogue and attempts to show what justice is and why it is in each person's best interest to be just. Socrates defines justice as having a rightly ordered soul. Just as a city is just when its different classes each fulfill their designated roles, an individual is just when the parts of their soul, which Socrates names the reasoning part, the spirited part, and the desiring part, also fulfill their appropriate functions in harmony. To him, this means that our reasoning part must rule over our desires and spiritedness since the reasoning part of our soul is most specific to our human nature. If we let our more animalistic parts of the soul rule over the reasoning part, we are essentially dehumanizing or "de-naturing" ourselves. The just man with a soul ruled by reason achieves some level of happiness through the

pursuit of knowledge and truth, which aligns with their soul's natural function, leading to inner harmony and a life guided by reason rather than fleeting desires.

Plato's vision of the rightly ordered soul, governed by reason and directed toward the good, not only set the tone for the following seminar sequences but also set the tone for the rest of the year. It helped us see that true freedom is found in virtue, and that education is ultimately about the formation of the whole person. Plato offers a philosophical defense grounded in his observation of order and laws of the natural world, emphasizing a life directed toward virtue and truth. He arrives at these conclusions through human reason alone, without recourse to divine revelation. It was helpful to grasp this reality as I was beginning to share in a year with these very things in mind through study, work, prayer, and community.

The Old Testament grounded our intellectual journey in divine revelation and taught us to see the world through the same lens of truth that Plato did. Plato proposed the existence of a higher, unchanging reality of perfect Forms, including virtues like justice and wisdom, pointing to objective truth and moral excellence. The Old Testament deepens this by revealing these truths as grounded in a personal, sovereign God who creates,



my last presentation on "the Inseparability of Love and Knowledge In the Life of a Disciple"

orders, and redeems all things. Reading the Old Testament helped form a biblical worldview where God is sovereign and Lord of history, where human beings are created in His image, where sin has consequences, and where hope is never lost. From the creation of the world in Genesis, where God brings order out of chaos and declares all creation good, to His calling of Abraham and the establishment of a covenant that would make him the father of a great nation, we began to trace the outlines of God's providential plan for humanity. In the Psalms, we encountered the poetic expression of Israel's faith: prayers of lament, thanksgiving, and praise that reflect a deep trust in God's justice and mercy. Through all these texts, we entered into the sacred drama of salvation history: a story of God revealing Himself, forming a people, and preparing the way for the fullness of His self-revelation in Christ. These texts reveal the human condition in all its beauty and brokenness, as well as God's relentless faithfulness and desire to dwell among His people. Most importantly, the books of the Old Testament, through prophecies and foreshadowings, illuminate the depth of Christ's mission and show how the Church is the fulfillment of God's covenantal plan.



seminar with Fr. Francisco Nahoe in Poland



walking into our seminar room in Poland

In *The Iliad* and *The Odyssey*, we encountered epic stories that provide a framework for understanding important concepts like virtue, death, and the afterlife in the ancient Greek world. Homer's perspective on virtue, mortality, and the afterlife depicts a reality in which individuals strive for excellence primarily for the sake of glory. In this view, death is portrayed as an unavoidable fate, while the afterlife is a bleak existence that does not offer any true reward or punishment.

We do see some compatibility with Christianity and the Greek understanding of virtue, as many of the greater heroes in Homer's works tend to prioritize these virtues even over their fear of death. However, the broader vision that shaped Greek heroic ideals leaves fundamental questions unanswered, particularly regarding the ultimate purpose of virtue and the meaning of life after death. Today, we are privileged by a post-incarnation worldview since Christ has resolved these dilemmas for us. Our Lord redefines virtue, offering victory over death through resurrection, and presents an afterlife governed by divine justice rather than fate. In doing so, Christ transforms the human understanding of existence and offers a hope and purpose that the Homeric world cannot provide. These works reminded us that even before Christ, the human heart yearned to transcend to something beyond war, glory, or comfort. The *Iliad* and the *Odyssey* reflect the confusion and despair that arise from a life without Christ, something not only true of Homer's pre-Christian world, but increasingly evident in our own society as it drifts

further from Christianity. In this way, Homer's epics not only reflect the spiritual limitations of a pre-Christian worldview but also underscore the enduring human longing for a deeper truth which finds its fulfillment in Christ's redemption.

Finally, Aristotle's *Nicomachean Ethics* provided a framework to understand virtue not as abstract idealism but as the very pattern of a good life. He offers a grounded, practical vision of human flourishing. Aristotle's insistence that virtue is a habit cultivated through action reminded us that philosophy is not just theoretical, but a roadmap for life. His exploration of virtue as well as friendship, self-mastery, and the pursuit of happiness gave us tools to think more deeply about our own character and the responsibility we hold in forming this character. This emphasis resonates deeply with the life the Fellows and I were trying to live together. In bridging the gap between philosophy and daily practice, Aristotle's insights continue to shape not only our individual pursuit of virtue but also our shared journey toward a life of freedom, mission, and discipleship.



Fr. Francisco joined us again for our end of the year retreat to give conferences



John giving a talk at the Via House on the Eucharist

At the heart of the Catholic vision of the human person is the belief that we are made in the image and likeness of God. Part of that divine image is our capacity to reason. Unlike animals, who act on instinct, human beings can seek truth, contemplate meaning, and deliberate with reason. It is this rational soul—our intellect and will—that makes us uniquely human. When we engage in intellectual formation, we are exercising the deepest, most innate part of ourselves. We are living out what it means to be human in the fullest sense.

Having the opportunity to dive into these works with the assistance of someone like our tutor John Lindsley has truly been a once-in-a-lifetime experience. To have someone deeply in tune with the truth and with Western intellectual tradition guiding our reading of such significant and crucial works can be extremely transformative. He

consistently drew meaning out of the texts that I would have otherwise overlooked, teaching us not what to think, but how to think, how to ask meaningful questions, discern falsehoods, seek truth with humility, and see how these texts speak to the soul and shape our journey toward sanctity.

I believe reading these works and taking time to discuss them can do more than just give you

practical knowledge; they can form you. They sharpen your capacity for reason and better equip you to step into the world not as a passive observer, but as an intentional, discerning follower of Christ. I learned to better articulate what I believe, see how God speaks through reason and beauty, and navigate the challenges of pursuing holiness in today's complex world.

WORK

Working as a medical assistant at Acadiana OBGYN has been an incredibly enriching experience, especially as someone discerning a future in the medical field. I had mentioned in my fall newsletter the clinic's Catholic mission of respecting the dignity of women and building a new culture of life. This mission adds a deeper sense of purpose and compassion to the care we provide, and it has been inspiring to see how faith and medicine can work hand in hand to serve others. My coworkers have been exceptionally supportive. They are always eager to teach and involve me in hands-on learning, whether it's administering new tests or taking patient vitals. Every day brings a new opportunity to grow, not only in clinical skills but also in understanding what it truly means to care for the whole person.

Not only through working at Acadiana OBGYN but also through spiritual direction, formation meetings, and prayer, have I come to have a clearer understanding of vocation—not simply as a career path, but as a call to serve with integrity and purpose. Mentors and formators encouraged me to bring my whole self into the workplace: to be someone who doesn't compartmentalize faith from work, but who lets faith inform every decision and relationship.

PRAYER

The structures of the year offer a frequent invitation into deeper intimacy with Christ. The rhythm of daily prayer, liturgy, spiritual direction, and retreat was not just an addition to our schedule but rather the wellspring of everything else. The spiritual life should not be seen as one more "area" of life, but as the center from which all other parts flow. Although daily mass and



the Fellows praying in some of the churches we visited in Austria and Poland

Last fall, we went on pilgrimage to Wyoming, and in February, we traveled to New Orleans. This spring, we were blessed to go to Europe—specifically Austria and Poland. While there, we visited many churches, monasteries, and castles. Each day, we celebrated Mass, spent time in prayer, & participated in seminars led by Father Francisco Nahoe, OFM Conv. It was an amazing experience, but unfortunately, I couldn't fit anymore into this newsletter to detail it all. I hope the pictures suffice:)

daily prayer are obligatory this year, I have found that there is still a deep desire for prayer and relationship with the Lord within this routine. In fact, the routine itself seems to deepen this desire and we are also still given the opportunity to take ownership of this pursuit by being responsible for fitting these things into our day during the weekend or while on break.



daily morning prayer in the chapel at Our Lady of Fatima

I have found that this routine of prayer and the sacraments creates spiritual habits that become a way to stay rooted amid noise. These habits have also cultivated more of an awareness of the need to discern God's will in everything—and I really mean everything. It can become easy to share parts of our life with God and allow him to work in those and then keep the rest mostly to ourselves. What has helped me move beyond that is the way this year integrated all areas of life: spiritual, intellectual, communal, and professional. In this kind of environment, where study, work, prayer, and daily responsibilities all share a common purpose rooted in the divine, I feel I've come to share in a new perspective—one that longs for God to envelop every aspect

of my life. This new perspective has led me to reconsider several decisions I made without this reality in mind. While these reconsiderations can feel a bit unsettling at times, I know it will only serve to bring me hope and comfort. I believe this hope and comfort arises from letting go of choices shaped by fear or illusion and instead trying to align them more closely with what is good and true, not what merely seems convenient or expected.

It was in these new perspectives that I came to recognize prayer not only as a place of encounter and of transformation, but also of complete surrender. Continual prayer and reception of the sacraments, as well as our studies, community life, weekly street walks, hosting events and many other aspects of the year has taught me that true intimacy with Christ doesn't come from isolated moments, but from a life continually turned toward Him—in routine, in rest, and in responsibility.

COMMUNITY

Community life was one of the greatest gifts of this year and, I believe, played a crucial role in helping me take advantage of what the other aspects of the year offered. Living this very full yet fulfilling life with others who value deep, holistic formation and are striving for holiness in very concrete ways, fostered deep friendships and accountability. Community life held up a mirror to my habits and character and often, my need for patience and humility. I recently read St. Teresa of Avila's writings on friendship, and a quote that encapsulates these writings well is, "What a great favor God does



Cajun music and dancing at the Via House

to those He places in the company of good people.” I’ve come to see how true that is. The friendships formed here were unique and meaningful, rooted in a common pursuit of truth, goodness, and holiness. Separate from the challenges and the growth that come from living in community is the pure joy I experienced with this group— joy in the shared meals, late-night bonfires, communal prayer, random games, group hikes, and simply in sharing life together. I saw the Church vividly alive in both the Via Fellows and also those who consistently showed up to the events we hosted every weekend. When 30 to 60 people show up on a Saturday night for dinner, a talk on sacred liturgy, and night prayer you begin to realize how many people are hungry for truth and looking to deepen their faith. There is great hope in the way the Church is alive through communities pursuing holiness together. It was in this hope, and in the simple joys of living the ordinary rhythms of Via with the Fellows, that I came to appreciate the profound gift of sharing life with others.

There are innumerable fruits and graces I received from this year that I truly do not have enough space to write about. I believe I am not even fully aware of these fruits right now, but they will continue unfolding in the years to come.



Votivkirche, or “Votive Church,”
in Vienna, Austria



more pictures from Austria
and Poland

CONCLUSION

In all, this year has been a profound reminder of the necessity of becoming more fully who I was created to be. I know true formation and holiness continue long after this program ends so I hope to carry with me the habits, lessons, and graces of this year. I feel much more confident to live out the faith in a world that is constantly fighting against it. This

will never feel easy and will take a resolute will, a spirit of sacrifice and detachment, and the grace of God, but I do believe I have been equipped with the right tools to keep me steadfast in this struggle. I am leaving not with all the answers, but with a heart more open to God's will and a life more aligned with His purposes, or at least an awareness that this is necessary.

There are so many people I owe a great amount of gratitude to that have made this year happen and have made it what it is. I want to thank Luke and John for their constant dedication to this program and for the sacrifice of time and effort it takes to make this an incredibly fruitful experience for the Fellows and for the wider community. Thank you to Dr. Cudihiy and Dr. Voltz for letting me on the team at the OBGYN, and to all my co-workers who were so enthusiastic about making sure I get the most out of this experience. Thank you to my spiritual director, formators, friends, and family for the constant prayers, support, and guidance. Lastly, thank you to my donors for your financial support and for any ways in which you have prayed for me or for Via. This would not have been possible without any of you!



Thank You!

